FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Guts and glory. Against all odds. Comeback champion. We casually resort to such clichés to describe sporting triumphs that involve a turnaround in fortunes. But the rawness of the emotions eludes us. We don't feel the undercurrent of fear, the crushing weight of dismay or the fire of ambition in which an Olympic medal is forged. The Manu Bhaker story, for us, is about Paris. The first Indian woman shooter to win an Olympic medal. The first athlete from independent India to win two medals in the same Olympics. However, what makes her achievement even more remarkable is the back story leading up to the previous Olympics in Tokyo. It's a story that holds much wisdom and inspiration.

In 2018, when she's 16, Jaspal Rana enters the picture, taking her under his tutelage as national junior coach. A celebrated shooter of his time, Rana grooms Manu like "a parent and a friend", allowing her to explore life as a young girl but cracking the whip on training days. She sees him as a "father figure" and has "blind faith" in his method. She travels to the World Cup in Mexico, winning multiple golds. The same year, she sets a Commonwealth record. The pairing was supposed to produce magic in Tokyo. Hit by Covid, the Olympics is delayed by a year and is now slated for July-August 2021. This is where things begin to go wrong.



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Though she won three golds, a silver and a bronze in different events at the World Cup in New Delhi in March 2021, cracks develop between coach and disciple. Rana suggests dropping one event out of the three she's planning to participate in at Tokyo because it would be too much. She feels he's favouring another player and not giving her enough attention. The acrimony goes out of hand, with allegations of ego on both sides. Rana is even sacked as team coach three months before Tokyo. As for Manu, she walks right into a brain-freeze moment on the big stage. She was a girl of 19. In her first Olympics, it was prophesied that she would own it. But out there in the loneliness of the moment, composure betrays her. She's thrown into an inexplicable paralysis of will and action. "I entirely forgot how I shoot, my technique, the process," she tells INDIA TODAY. The mental trough she plunged into was such that she contemplate quitting altogether. Most teenagers would have been scarred for life. It's from that wreckage that she reassembled her life. Two years later, she exhibited astounding maturity for someone still only 21 and initiated a rapprochement with Rana at a meeting at a Starbucks in Delhi. She then goes on to make history for her country.

This week's cover story gives you the inside story of how Manu exorcised the ghosts of failure at Tokyo 2020 and returned with all pistols blazing in Paris 2024. Deputy Editor Suhani Singh talks to Manu, her family, friends, shooting colleagues and, most importantly, coach Rana to piece together the inspiring saga of how a champion is made on the inside. You also get a series of stunning gun-toting shots she poses for sportingly. Group Photo Editor Bandeep Singh's visuals capture the Manu Bhaker story as much as anything else: a happy girl who enjoys shopping, likes to be "creative" with her sartorial choices and doesn't mind the attention. But the core of that persona is as hard and unerring as a bullet that knows where to go.

It didn't take her long to get there. She was born in a Haryana village, but to a prosperous, educated family. The father is a chief engineer in the merchant navy, and the mother a Sanskrit teacher and principal at the village school that the grandfather has set up. Manu wants to "be strong and feel powerful" and does boxing, kabaddi, karate and the Manipuri martial art thang-ta. Sent out of history class one day for "sleeping or eating", the 14-year-old wanders into the school shooting range and falls for the hypnotic charm of looking at a target, aiming at it with a gun, calming her breath and her mind, and pulling the trigger. She gets so good at it that, within a year, she's winning national gold medals.

Shooting, as a sport, evolved out of hunting and war. Patience and physical strength are its cornerstones. You need to bring your gun hand to eye level and hold it rock-steady, raising and lowering it repeatedly. Her early martial arts training gave her that upper body strength. But you also need to hit the meditative state of a yogi to control your 'monkey mind' and concentrate on a singular spot in front of you. The history-making double bronze medal she won at Paris through sheer grit, making India proud, is a study in unwavering focus on long-term targets.

Since our last female sporting star P.V. Sindhu slid off the podiums, India has taken to this winsome young lady with a gun. She wears her newfound stardom with ease and an infectious smile. She's walking the ramp at fashion weeks. Her social media footfalls have sashayed into the millions. Like any other Gen Z-er, she moves with the comfort of a digital native on Instagram, not averse to make-up or cutting a striking figure. But she's got a head on her shoulders, one that knows how to be still and shut out the noise while taking aim. Her next big target is winning gold in Los Angeles 2028. That should not be too difficult for our double-medal champion.

(Aroon Purie)